



Fundamentals of Human Resource Management (HRM1)

Module 7: Job Analysis, Design and Evaluation

Lesson 3: Job Evaluation

Lesson Notes

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What Is Job Evaluation, and the Distinction Between Jobs and Roles

Job evaluation is the systematic process of analysing and assessing various jobs to determine their relative worth within an organisation, based on their content, placing them in order of importance. It is important to note that job evaluation ranks jobs, not job holders. Job holders themselves are assessed separately, through performance appraisal, covered in the next module (Armstrong, 2006).

Job evaluation serves several objectives: gathering information on job descriptions, specifications, and requirements; comparing the duties and demands of different jobs; determining the hierarchy of jobs within the organisation's structure; determining appropriate ranks or grades; and ensuring fair, equitable wages, so that jobs of genuinely equal worth receive equal pay. Its guiding principles are straightforward: rate the job, not the employee; use rating elements that are easily understood and clearly defined; and involve supervisors in the rating process.

A useful distinction sits underneath job evaluation: the difference between a job and a role. A job is an organisational unit consisting of a defined group of tasks or duties to be performed. A role, by contrast, is the part played by an individual and the pattern of behaviour expected of them in fulfilling their work, defined by Ivancevich et al. (2008) as an organised set of behaviours. Jobs are about tasks; roles are about people. A generic role describes essentially similar activities carried out by many people, such as a call centre agent, covering an occupation rather than one single position. A role profile, unlike a rigid job description, defines outcomes, accountabilities, and competencies for an individual role, focusing on results rather than a fixed list of duties, which gives people more flexibility in how they actually achieve those results.

A Ugandan bank might have a formal job description for every teller role, but two individual tellers, given the same job, may develop noticeably different roles over time, one becoming known informally as the team's go-to problem solver for difficult customers, the other focusing more narrowly on transaction speed, even though both hold identical job titles.

Reflect: Think of two people you know who hold the exact same job title. Have their actual roles, in the sense described here, ended up looking different from each other, and if so, how?

Analytical Job Evaluation, Point-Factor Rating and Analytical Matching

Analytical job evaluation breaks whole jobs down into defined elements or factors, such as responsibility, decision making, and required knowledge and skills, assumed to be present in every job being evaluated, but to differing degrees. Its advantage is that evaluators must consider each characteristic of a job separately before reaching an overall conclusion, using defined guidelines that increase objectivity and consistency, and in some jurisdictions, analytical schemes can even provide a legal defence against equal pay claims.

Point-factor rating is the most common analytical scheme. Jobs are broken into factors such as expertise, decision making, autonomy, responsibility, and interpersonal skills. Each factor is allocated a maximum points score, sometimes weighted explicitly if some factors are considered more significant than others, and each factor is divided into levels with an associated numerical scale. Jobs are then scored against each factor by comparing the actual features of the job to the factor level definitions to find the best fit, and the separate factor scores are added together to produce a total score that ranks the job relative to others.

Analytical matching works similarly but compares role profiles, already analysed and described in terms of job evaluation factors, against a set of grade or level profiles described using the same factors, to find the best fit. This is often used in larger organisations to grade generic roles quickly, once an initial evaluation of a representative sample of benchmark jobs has already been completed, without repeating the full point-factor process for every single role.

A Ugandan university evaluating academic staff roles might use point-factor rating with factors such as teaching load, research output, and administrative responsibility, allowing it to justify pay differences between a lecturer and a senior lecturer based on genuinely defined, comparable criteria rather than informal judgement.

Reflect: *Why might a point-factor scheme be considered fairer than simply asking a manager to rank jobs by gut feeling?*

Non-Analytical Job Evaluation Methods

Non-analytical job evaluation compares whole jobs to place them in a grade or rank order, without breaking them down into separate factors. These methods are simpler to introduce and operate, but provide no defined standard of judgement and offer no real defence in an equal value dispute.

Job classification compares a whole job description against a defined hierarchy of grade descriptions to find the best overall match, without analysing the job factor by factor. Job ranking, the most basic form of job evaluation, simply compares whole jobs against each other and arranges them in order of perceived value, without attempting to quantify the comparison. Paired comparison ranking is a more structured version of whole-job ranking, comparing each job separately against every other job: a job considered more important than the one it is compared to receives two points, an equally important job receives one point, and a less important job receives none, with total scores producing a rank order. This method becomes demanding quickly, since evaluating fifty jobs would require over a thousand individual comparisons. Internal benchmarking compares the job under review against an internal job already believed to be properly graded and paid, placing the job under consideration into that same grade, a method people often use intuitively even without formally calling it job evaluation.

A small Ugandan NGO with only fifteen staff might reasonably use internal benchmarking, comparing a newly created programme officer role to an existing, well established finance officer role already known to be fairly graded, rather than investing in a full point-factor scheme better suited to a much larger organisation.

Reflect: For a small organisation with limited HR expertise, would you recommend job ranking, paired comparison, or internal benchmarking, and why?

Bringing Job Analysis, Design and Evaluation Together

This module covered three closely connected processes. Job analysis studies a job as it currently exists, establishing its duties, environment, and requirements. Job design actively shapes how a job's tasks are organised, to reduce boredom, manage risk, and improve satisfaction. Job evaluation determines how much a job is worth relative to every other job in the organisation, most often to establish fair pay.

These three processes typically happen in sequence: an organisation first analyses what a job involves, then designs or redesigns it to be as effective as possible, and finally evaluates it to place it fairly within the organisation's pay structure. Skipping any one step tends to create problems in the others, poor analysis leads to poor design, and poor design makes fair evaluation far harder, since it becomes unclear exactly what is being evaluated in the first place.

The next module moves from these structural HR tools into performance appraisal and performance management, examining how organisations assess and improve the people actually doing these carefully analysed, designed, and evaluated jobs.